

10 Years of Surgical Strikes: India's Evolving Counterterrorism Strategy

A special broadcast analysis on strategic doctrine, technological modernization, and decisive diplomacy.

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION TO THE DISCUSSION

00:03 – 01:08

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [00:03 - 00:27]

Spotlight. *[music]* This is Akashwani. In the program Spotlight, now we bring a discussion on 10 years of surgical strikes, India's evolving counterterrorism strategy. The participants are Shekhar Iyer, senior journalist, and Anubhav Rohatgi, anchor.

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [00:27 - 01:01]

India is marking the 10th anniversary of surgical strikes on terrorist hideouts in Pakistan. On September 28–29, 2016, the Indian Army struck terror launch pads across the Line of Control in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir as a direct and decisive response to the Uri terror attack earlier that month. That operation demonstrated the change in India's approach to terrorism and laid the groundwork for subsequent military actions. In the Spotlight program tonight, we focus on how India's counterterrorism strategy has evolved over the years, and political analyst Shekhar Iyer now joins me to share his views on this issue. Mr. Iyer, welcome to Akashwani's Spotlight program.

SHEKHAR IYER [01:01 - 01:08]

Thank you. Thank you.

CHAPTER 2: IMPACT OF SURGICAL STRIKES

01:08 – 03:26

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [01:08 - 01:27]

Mr. Iyer, it's been a decade since India said enough is enough and decided to give a befitting reply to the years of pain it had been suffering due to terror attacks from across the border. Would you say that the September 2016 strikes were a defining moment in India's response to cross-border terrorism?

SHEKHAR IYER [01:27 - 02:27]

Indeed, Anubhav, that was, I would call, a turning point as to how India viewed attacks on its territory or its citizens, as well as how it should respond. The Indian response actually astonished the world, as the Prime Minister mentioned in *Mann Ki Baat*. You know, it demonstrated that this is a New India and it will not tolerate this kind of inhuman attacks on innocent civilians.

See, we have been facing this terrorist problem for more than three to four decades, and we had endured all this, as the Prime Minister put it. So what happened was that the very fact that our soldiers could go deep inside the Line of Control and take action against terrorists—damage their launching pads—sent a very, very clear message. And as you mentioned, this was the response to the Uri attack of September 18, 2016. And I think that woke up all our enemies as well as our friends.

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [02:27 - 03:26]

And since you have mentioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi mentioning the surgical strikes in his *Mann Ki Baat* program, let's first listen to what he said about the 10th anniversary... *[Audio Clip: Prime Minister addressing surgical strike operations]*

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [03:26 - 04:57]

Since Pakistan didn't mend its ways after Uri, India too responded with more such operations. So how has India's counterterrorism approach evolved from Uri to the Balakot air strike in 2019 and Operation Sindhur in 2025? The form and instruments of terrorism have changed over the years, and terror groups are increasingly using high-tech means. How would you assess India's response to these changes, evolving to use modern technology along with conventional military capabilities? We did see evidence of that evolution during Operation Sindhur last year.

SHEKHAR IYER [04:57 - 06:21]

Absolutely. Operation Sindhur showcased to the world the progression of India's zero-tolerance policy. If the attack on Uri camp was met with a strike across the border demolishing camps, from there to the Balakot strike of 2019—when our CRPF Jawans were targeted—we saw India making deep penetrations, what later came to be termed entering the adversary's threshold. The Prime Minister often emphasized that we will not hesitate to go deep into terror sanctuaries. Very few nations have exercised that resolve, and India stands firmly among them.

As terror groups adopt highly sophisticated technologies, it has necessitated matching responses beyond tactical actions alone. The national counterterrorism policy framework, **PRAHAR** (unveiled on February 23, 2026 by the Ministry of Home Affairs), signals a definitive transition: shifting from a historically reactive posture to a *Unified Proactive Doctrine*.

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [06:21 - 06:39]

Addressing the scourge of terrorism is no longer limited to just military operations, since terror groups increasingly resort to indirect assaults like cyber attacks on key energy and banking infrastructure. In this context, what is the role of PRAHAR, India's first comprehensive national counterterrorism policy and strategy?

SHEKHAR IYER [06:39 - 08:41]

The PRAHAR policy has two core pillars. One is targeting the roots of radicalization—tackling extremist propaganda, social media weaponization, and online recruitment misleading youth. The second pillar prepares for futuristic asymmetric warfare through extensive technological infrastructure investments.

Today we maintain continuous aerial surveillance, monitoring movements and communications. Investigative bodies such as the National Investigation Agency (NIA) have been heavily empowered with advanced tooling and resources to choke terror funding channels and dismantle syndicates. Crucially, addressing encrypted communications, dark web exploitation, and illicit cryptocurrency financing is key. Round-the-clock cyber task forces actively track malicious transactions and network recruitment, producing the precision intelligence demonstrated during Operation Sindhur.

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [08:41 - 08:56]

India's strategy has involved not simply crossing the LoC, but publicly acknowledging operations, organizing international briefings, and sending delegations abroad to explain India's zero-tolerance stance. How do you assess this approach?

SHEKHAR IYER [08:56 - 11:11]

Senior military leadership has detailed the operational planning behind Operation Sindhur, executed in response to the brutal terrorist attack targeting innocent civilians. From planning through execution, rigorous intelligence ensured maximum target neutralization while actively preventing civilian casualties. That reflects civilizational leadership. Unlike arbitrary cross-border strikes seen elsewhere, India conducted surgical, intelligence-backed actions against 11 designated bases. The calibrated employment of drone technology and containment compelled the adversary to seek a ceasefire, clearly realizing the disproportionate conventional risk of further escalation.

CHAPTER 6: POLITICAL RESOLVE AND STRATEGIC DIPLOMACY

11:11 – 14:14

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [11:11 - 11:20]

Along with military readiness, what role has political resolve played in shaping India's changing doctrine against cross-border terrorism over the last decade?

SHEKHAR IYER [11:20 - 13:44]

Decisive political will has been pivotal. While our Armed Forces and Special Forces have always possessed exceptional capability, institutional clarity and authorization from the highest political leadership proved decisive. Moving past defensive postures and reactive dossiers, the doctrine established unambiguous deterrence. Simultaneously, assertive multilateral diplomacy across the UN, BRICS, and high-level bilateral summits has forged global consensus against cross-border terrorism.

ANUBHAV ROHATGI (ANCHOR) [13:44 - 14:14]

Mr. Shekhar Iyer, thank you so much for joining Akashwani's Spotlight program and sharing your valuable insights on this issue. You were listening to a discussion on *10 Years of Surgical Strikes: India's Evolving Counterterrorism Strategy*.

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